that the president “has been seized with the idea of trading Turkish for Cuban missiles.”[6]

There is no indication that his commitment to that solution weakened in the course of the day. But in the discussion with Robert, the president approved a letter to Khrushchev drafted by him and Ted Sorensen that made no reference whatever to Turkey. An earlier draft had included the phrase, “You should just understand that the bases in Turkey are under NATO jurisdiction.” But the final version ignored Khrushchev’s swap offer altogether. The letter promised negotiations if Khrushchev halted the construction of missile sites in Cuba. The basis for negotiations was removal of the Soviet missiles under United Nations supervision. Based on that, the blockade would be lifted and assurances against invasion given by the United States and its Latin American allies.[7]

John Kennedy accepted Robert’s draft of the letter because he already had another plan: to send his brother to the Soviet ambassador, Anatoly Dobrynin, to negotiate the swap in secret. After his meeting with Robert, John Kennedy returned to the room where the ExCom was still in session and, after a brief discussion, asked selected members of ExCom to join him in the Oval Office. He did not want Lyndon Johnson around but invited McGeorge Bundy, who left us the only detailed recollection of what happened there. The main item on the agenda was the oral message that Robert Kennedy was to deliver to Dobrynin, along with the letter drafted by Robert and Ted Sorensen.

The American missiles in Turkey were the elephant in the room. Everyone knew that Kennedy wanted to trade them, but they were not mentioned in the letter to be delivered to Dobrynin. It was clear that Kennedy wanted his brother to discuss them with the Soviet ambassador, but how? Dean Rusk offered a solution: Robert would tell Dobrynin that while there could not be a publicly announced quid pro quo on the missiles in Cuba and Turkey, once the crisis was resolved on the basis of Kennedy’s letter the president would remove the American missiles from Turkey.[8]

The solution was as old as diplomacy itself—a secret deal. Rusk’s formula was based on an idea proposed by Raymond Hare, the American ambassador to Turkey, in a cable received in Washington earlier that day. One of Hare’s suggestions was “dismantling the Jupiters” either in “a more